

Style Me Up!

The first way to beautify an XML is the *Cascading Style Sheet* (CSS). It's usually used for HTML, but since its job is to recognise tags and apply colours or effects to them, it works just as well with XML too. This is what a CSS for our music collection would look like:

```
Collection
{
background-color: #ffffff;
width: 100%;
}

Track
{
display: block;
margin-bottom: 30pt;
margin-left: 0;
}
```

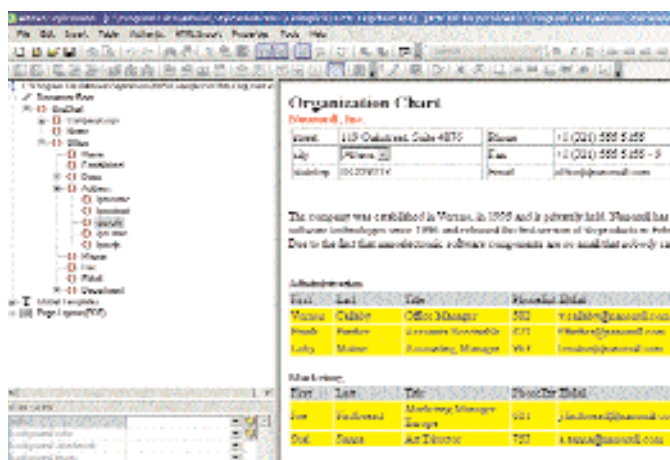
...and so on, for each tag. As you can see, the CSS can be used to assign height, width and even background colours, as well as display styles and margins.

You can write this style sheet in any text editor, and save it as “[filename].css”. To apply this style sheet to the XML, you will need to put this line in the XML file:

```
<?xml-stylesheet type="text/css" href="[filename].css"?>
```

This tells your browser to display the XML using the style sheet you just made.

CSS isn't a standard set by the W3C, and is quite limited in what it can do, so the Wise Men of XML don't advise its use. Instead, they point towards XML Stylesheet Language, or XSL. XSL offers a huge number of capabilities—it's practically a whole new programming language on its own. You can even specify conditions for formatting, using the classic: “if (condition) then (do this) else (do that)” structure that is common to all programming languages—like if you wanted your favourite artist to be shown in red, leaving the others in blue. Unfortunately though, XSL is a lot more difficult to learn than CSS, but there are a lot of tools that you could use to generate an XSL style sheet without having to know XSL itself.



Pretty-ing up an XML in StyleVision

1/2 pg V Ad